

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

Everyday Language Games

From first words to first sentences · Ages 1½–3

Children learn language through warm, back-and-forth conversation. These games fit into meals, bath time, walks and chores. No materials needed.

What the research found

- ○ The number of conversational turns children took with adults was linked to stronger language skills and brain activity in language areas (Romeo et al., 2018).

The three-period lesson (Montessori)

- ○ 1. Name it: hold up a spoon. “This is a spoon.” Repeat with 2 more objects.
- ○ 2. Recognise it: “Show me the spoon.” “Give me the cup.” Play this the longest.
- ○ 3. Recall it: “What is this?” Only when they're confident.
- ○ Use real objects: fruits, vegetables, kitchen tools, clothes.

Everyday talk

- ○ Narrate: “I'm pouring the milk. It's cold!”
- ○ Expand: child says “Dog!”, you say “Big brown dog!”
- ○ Wait: ask, then count to 5 silently.
- ○ Ask open questions: “What happened?” “What should we do?”
- ○ Sing rhymes and songs with actions.

Bilingual homes

Speaking your home language richly does not confuse children. Use the language you're most fluent and expressive in, and let children pick up others too.

When to check with a doctor

- ○ No words by about 16 months
- ○ No two-word phrases by about 2 years
- ○ Losing words or skills they had before

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Romeo, R. R., et al. (2018). Beyond the 30-million-word gap: Children's conversational exposure is associated with language-related brain function. Psychological Science, 29(5), 700–710.
Montessori, M. The Absorbent Mind (language).

General information, not medical advice.